Deception & Expectations

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man)

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by JazzKat1213

Summary

Meals at the Greyskull manor have never been comfortable but this is…Adam never touches her. They joke and talk with Adora also present, but now he's taken her hands to pull her up to stand and he hasn't let go.

"Miss Catra D'riluth, will you marry me?"
She's dreaded these words for years. She never once thought they'd come from Adam. Only Adora will know the extent of her shock by how her entire body stills.

I

Chapter Summary

A proposal.

Chapter Notes

I just wanted to write some temporary comphet and sibling marriage drama <3
I have no idea what Adam or Randor or Marlena are actually like in the old show. I just did what I wanted.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra D'riluth has been running off her family's money since she was a child, passed around from place to place since her caretakers kept dying until she was settled with distant and elderly relatives that would take her. She inherited enough when they too died, a townhouse on the outskirts of the city centre and a small trade business that has kept her from bankruptcy. At twenty-two her reputation hasn't recovered entirely from her teenage years when she would steal her uncle's clothes, run off to bars and gamble, refuse to give the time of day to any of her suitors. She started travelling just to escape it, her uncle mostly, but also the townspeople. Since returning - since her great uncle's funeral - said reputation has by far been repaired by one and only one person.

The Greyskull lineage is powerful, recognised. Lady Adora and herself became fast friends in youth during their joint schooling, originally to the disdain of the Earl and Countess. Not just a lower class but a hybrid too, and an orphan. And that was before her less than ladylike reputation set in. That never mattered to Adora; she always stayed by her side, affectionate and caring. She defended her at every turn until she befriended Lord Adam as well. There was little the Earl and Countess could say about her

character that would not reflect badly on their own children for liking her so much.

Aside from her travels, there have been few days in her life where Catra has not seen Adora. And even then she wrote to her weekly, not that Adora could correspond regularly with her changing addresses so often. But they tried. And succeeded for the most part. She sent a note up to the manor as soon as got home, Adora was at her door and then in her arms within the hour. Catra took to scenting her friend like she would die without it.

The scandal she caused died down with her time away, as planned. She's been on her best behaviour ever since, dulling all her instincts when she's outside to overcompensate, trying to be the proper lady she ought to be. That doesn't kill the whispers in the streets. How can it when they're not even wrong?

"Miss D'riluth is not trying to steal our money."
Adora has tried to convince her parents of this for the past three years since Catra's return from her travels. They see her near daily and are still not convinced of her goodness, and she is tired of caring. Low station, orphan, bad luck, hybrid, scandal waiting to happen; she's heard them all. She knows there are rumours of her dearest friend, that there have been since death seemed to follow Catra like a shadow and she ended up with her great uncle and aunt in the first place, since she wore clothes everyone else thought strange. People are careful of what they say to her face, however. Which is good on a number of levels; she doubts her parents would accept her defending Catra as a viable excuse for causing a scene. Especially when they are the ones she actually hears speaking ill of Catra.

"But she is so often here."
She doesn't know what Marlena is trying to get out of her, or trying to prove, but it has become even more tiresome recently.
"At my request, because I adore her, mother."

“I know you do, but you surely don’t send for her *every* day? She comes here of her own volition too.”
Catra doesn’t come *every* day…just most of them. “Well yes, because she knows she is welcome. She gets bored and lonely in that house of hers, it’s not as if they'd let her actually run her own company. And I can only take so much of my brother.”
Marlena sighs, looking at her like she just doesn’t understand. It happens far too often. “One can never be too careful with names like ours.”
“With all respect, mother, I disagree.”

The Earl Greyskull has always unnerved Catra. Marlena makes her fur bristle, but Randor, she just doesn’t know what he thinks or might do until he makes it obvious.
“Miss D’riluth, may we talk in my study?”
It's not a request - he isn't a man that *makes* requests. The power he wields…he can ban her from his land, from ever seeing Adora again. It’s always terrified her, always makes her tail curl around her ankle. Just like it does now. “Of course, Lord Courtesy.”

It shouldn't feel like a march to an executioner's block, but she's always been dramatic. She has never been in his study, she's rarely been alone with him at all where there wasn't something terribly serious weighing down on the conversation. This will be no different. She likes the emerald green fabric on the walls, not that she could afford that but a wallpaper replica perhaps. Randor sits at the dark wooden desk, the light from the window behind him makes him look that much more imposing. She is not relaxing until she is out of this room.

“After years, my wife has convinced me to have this conversation with you.”
If the Countess has gotten her husband to do this…well there’s dread settling in steadily. “This sounds an ominous matter.”
“In a way it is. The Countess and I wish to understand your reasons for being here so often.”

There is an easy answer at least. “Your daughter is my dearest friend, one of my only. Her time means everything to me.”

He sighs, “After all these years, I am hesitant in my more unflattering assumptions of you. Your loyalty has always been admirable. The Countess, however, still firmly believes there is more.”
Her chest sinks and she hopes her ears don’t give her away.
“More to what, Lord Courtesy?”
“Your motivations, friendship only goes so far, even one as long-standing as yours. We have our name to think of -”
“- My rebellious days are behind me. You of all people know that.”
'I did it for you,' remains unsaid. She thinks he knows that.
If she had the choice, she'd be in a trouser suit this very moment, she might even have cut her hair. She has culled her behaviour out of self preservation and that alone. But she tries to reassure him as a distraction. Friendship does only go so far, her relationships with Scorpia and Entrapta have proven that to her. There is fear in her chest asking pitifully: why now of all times must he ask this? Why ask at all?

“I forgave your scandal a long time ago, Miss D'riluth. You know that." She doesn't *believe* it, however. "You moved past it swiftly and with delicacy. But I know that your connection to us helped that greatly, and the Countess, I believe, wants a confession of sorts. *I* am only asking for an explanation as to you being here so often, save your friendship with my daughter.”
“I can reduce my time here, Lord Courtesy, if that is what you are asking of me.”
“It is not. The time itself is not the issue, with their schooling done the distraction you pose to my children does not matter so much… Even if you simply admit that your time here is to maintain your status through our name, we will accept that until the day it seeks to harm us.”
“It - it isn’t that, it never has been.”

They’re right to be suspicious, at least slightly. Names like theirs are precious and held tight to their own class. But she can’t give him the truth. Not if she ever wants to see Adora again. She’s not

going to lose her. She won’t survive it - how low and dark she became if she didn’t hear from her for a month or longer made that known to her. But she can’t think of anything else to tell him. She 'admits' that she's here for social gain and Marlena will weave it into her children's heads that that is all she wants from them. And anything else will only slander her own name again and make Randor harsher with her. She can't even leave here without consequences, maybe even punishment for rudeness. Her uncle had that instilled in her young.

So she grits her teeth, wraps her arms around herself and forces out, “Lord Courtesy, would you accept love?”
She isn’t saying it. She isn’t. She’s never been completely sure, but at this point she thinks it’s only denial allowing that. It’s not a *lie* no matter how he takes it, it does no discredit to her reputation so long as he does not realise the full truth - that is what’s important.
He looks even more shocked than she expected, “Love? You are here for love?”
“Unfortunately, I believe so.”

Adam proposes to her three weeks later. No courtship - that she’s aware of - and in front of the whole family. Meals at the Greyskull manor have never been comfortable but this is…Adam never touches her. They joke and talk with Adora also present, but now he’s taken her hands to pull her up to stand and he hasn’t let go.

“Miss Catra D’riluth, will you marry me?”
She’s dreaded these words for years. She never once thought they’d come from Adam. Only Adora will know the extent of her shock by how her entire body stills.
“Lord Greyskull, I - when - what’s brought this on?”
He’s smiling nervously and genuine, the same way Adora does when she's not entirely sure what answer she’ll receive. It makes her feel ill. “I know it’s sudden, and I’m not asking for an answer now. But I think this could be good, for both of us.”

He’s waiting for something - anything - from her. But all she can see are Adora’s eyes in his face.

It’s not the first time she’s detested her best friend having a twin. Why couldn’t she love *him*? He is kind like Adora, smart like her, same sense of humour for the most part, but whatever the differences are - and she does know them inside out - they are apparently insurmountable to her feelings. She curses her own name silently, wishing she could love the right one, wishing she could be happy about this. She wishes to feel anything other than betrayal.

She takes her hands back, looking away so she doesn’t have to see his reaction. But she sees Adora instead, there’s tear-shine and distress and it pains her to see.
“I - excuse me.”
She runs. Like she’s so good at.
The clothes of a proper lady don’t allow her to run on all fours, she’s never hated it more than right now. She hates dresses, she hates being caught off guard like this, and she hates how utterly distraught Adora looked. She hates letting her down.

Catra ends up at the well hidden in the less-seen depths of Marlena’s sprawling flower garden. The cold, mossy stone against her palms is grounding. She’s not crying, she isn’t even sad, but breathing is difficult. She is angry, and she is confused. It takes her a while to figure that out. She felt safe here - safe enough - and now there’s even more things for her to run from and deny. Her tail won’t stop lashing.

Her ears catch footfalls and she considers leaping into a tree, but the only voice she can stand to hear right now calls out, “Catra!” She keeps staring into the water, not helping but Adora knows she likes it out here, she’ll find her. She always does. She waits, not relaxing at all even as Adora gets close enough that the wind has her scent. Adora’s hand comes to rest on her arm when she’s close enough.
“Adora, did you know?”
The hand on her arm holds tighter, Adora’s other cups her cheek

and pulls her head around to meet blue eyes. They're so similar to Adam's just minutes ago, only sadder.
"No. No, I didn't know. Catra, believe me I didn't." Adora's fingers scratch lightly at the underside of her jaw but it doesn't make her purr, she appreciates it anyway. "I don't…maybe we should both be happy?"
Maybe her scoff is too harsh, she doesn't care.

Adora lets her go with a sigh, and Catra stops her tail from wrapping around her to keep her close. Adora sits down on the stone, apparently not caring if it scuffs the delicate pale blue of her dress. She's always looked so pretty in blue.
"I just don't understand why he's done this. We haven't been courting, he hasn't said *anything* until today. He knows how much I hated the parade of suitors my uncle had me - I was sure he knew how I felt, how I still *do*!"
Her claws add a new set of marks to the stone. The Adam she knows wouldn't *do* this. Not to her.

She sighs and turns to sit, thankful that laying her head on Adora's shoulder is easy even with her secret. Adora always puts an arm around her waist, leans on her too. It's then that she realises that a lot of her sickening anxiety comes from knowing that no matter what things are changing. At best Adam calls it off and they go back to trying to be friends but she'll always feel *off* about it. At worst she loses Adora completely. Because it always comes back to that fear.

"Would you stay with me tonight?"
Adora whispers, "Of course."
She won't ask for Adora to be in her bed, not outright. But somehow she ends up there anyway, just following, and Catra never sends her away - she could never. Catra never shows her another room despite having them, despite Adora knowing. She trills weakly when Adora kisses her forehead before standing.
Adora tugs on her hand saying, "Let's go sneak around the back and get your carriage."
She stands too and Adora doesn't let go. *This* is what she needs,

no one else's hands to hold hers. “Your things?”
“I can use yours?”

They’ve done it before and Adora will look poorly put together in the morning. Catra likes it, but they have the Greyskull name to think of. And the Earl made it clear that his daughter should not be exiting her house in the morning in a strange state. Like everything else it seems, it would cause talk and scandal.
“You really don’t want to go inside, do you?”
“No...but I have to don’t I, to tell them?”
Adora says that like she’s ever been able to leave her family grounds without notice before. She’s the Lady of Greyskull manor, there things they just can't do. And after running from the Lord Greyskull’s proposal, now would be an abysmal time for Catra to break that unspoken rule.
“You do. Get your things, find Mara, have her tell them.”
Adora starts pulling her along the path, smiling, “You’re so clever.”

Chapter End Notes

Floor plans for Catra's house

II

Chapter Summary

Adjusting.

Chapter Notes

Only Adora ever calling Catra by just her first name is very important to me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra asks Mara not to let anyone but the Earl know that she's called the next time she goes to the Manor Greyskull, and she's shown once again into Randor's study. She does not *storm* in, but close enough to it.
"What happens to me if I reject your son's advances?"
She's been consumed by the question since she left the grounds two days ago, and she doesn't even remember to address him by his title.
Randor doesn't seem to realise that as he looks up from his papers. "You are in love, so unless you are lying, why would you reject him?"
She'd slam her hands on the desk if she thought she could stop herself clawing it, instead she hisses, "What *happens*?"
She's being demanding and rude - her uncle would have a fit if he were still alive - and Randor is clearly not used to it. Dire circumstances, he can handle it. He leans back in his seat, at least looking like he is considering how to answer.
"Well, I would imagine it would be difficult for him to be around you. Your time here would be reduced significantly, if not completely to save him the reminder and embarrassment."

"…Could I still see Adora?" That's all that matters.
"You know how infrequently she leaves the grounds."
'Because of you.'
Coming here is a choice from both of them. They can't be

watched in her townhouse, by anyone. Adora's parents wanted to keep an eye on both of them in the beginning when she returned from abroad, between the situation preceding her leaving and their priority of making sure Adora stays *protected*. It took Catra a while to figure it out, but the Countess is not good at hiding her rigidity whenever Adora so much as mentions a man without a title. It's about marriage, of course it is, whether Adora is aware of that or not. But on her darker days, Catra can't stop herself from bitterly thinking that it's to prevent Adora bringing in anymore *strays*.

"I wasn't lying. I just think I would reflect badly on him, on you. I know how you and the Countess feel about my station. I know you want your children to marry well, every parent does. I don't do well in high society, you've seen it. And the - the *children* we might have. The Greyskull name to be carried on by *me*?"
"You may not have a title, Miss D'riluth, but the Countess and I are looking past it. With your motivations out in the open, she seems ready to forgive a great many things, we both are. She wants her son happy and settled, and cares about that more than what any future grandchildren might look like. Though she did begrudgingly admit that they would not be ugly."

They would look like Adora. They could be mistaken for *her* children if that were at all possible. She doesn't want to be a mother, and she can't imagine raising them if they had blonde fur and blue eyes. Everything would just sting that much worse, not a day would go by without reminders that she is…perverted in her desires. She wants everything to just stop for a moment and let her panic subside.
"If we ignore…a great many things, I simply don't think I would make a good wife, Lord Courtesy."
His look softens to something far kinder, it disarms her. "Adam could do far worse than you, Miss D'riluth. And he wants to do this for you, told me so himself."

Marlena starts hovering constantly whenever she is at the manor, being unsettlingly nice. It's worse than her disdain. The woman is already teaching her how the house is run, how to take care of things. The Countess keeps catching her frowning and pats her on the cheek, telling her, *"We'll make a Lady out of you yet, Miss D'riluth."*
And when Adora comes to save her, nothing exactly gets better since Adora grows quiet at every subtle reminder of the situation. She feels like she can't even bring herself to keep pretending she hasn't made a decision. Not that she *has* a decision.

She leads Adam out to Marlena's pavilion a week to the date - nearly to the hour - after the initial question. It's a gorgeous place, one she's always been too afraid of ruining by entering. The woman gave her express permission for it however, in fact she's probably watching them from a window.
"I'm accepting your proposal," she hopes it doesn't sound as forced as it feels.
"You are?"
"Yes, my Lord. I can't imagine there being anyone better for me than you."
Adam's blinding smile isn't exactly worth everything that's going to come after this, but it's alright for the moment. He pulls a ring out of his pocket that she is entirely unprepared for, it feels heavy as he puts it on.

She doesn't know what comes next, she hopes he doesn't try to kiss her. She has an excuse ready, but it's not needed. A kiss on the hand, and holding out an arm for her to take, she can bear that. He's the picture of a polite, chaste Lord. (Marlena would be so proud.) He chatters excitedly as they walk the grounds, it's almost childish. She gets the maybe unfair sense that he doesn't realise the seriousness of what he's done. To everyone else she has just given him her future, she knows he'll be more careful with it than anyone else…but she just can't stop the dread.

She doesn't know how long they're outside for, but when Adam walks her back to the manor, he tells her, "My sister has been

miserable all week, go give her the good news."
He's right, Adora's boundless energy has been completely absent. Marlena comes out of the sitting room, wrapping her son up in an embrace. She at least happier than Catra's ever seen her.
"You did say yes, didn't you, dear?" So she was watching then.
"Yes, Lady Courtesy."

Marlena grabs her hand without warning and she has to keep her hand rigid to stop the claws ripping the delicate fabric of Marlena's gloves. She hopes the touch isn't going to be a common thing but given the way the week has been going she's not sure.
"Oh and Adam gave you the ring! We haven't had a wedding here since mine and the Earl's, we'll have to dress the manor up -"
"- Be careful, Lady Courtesy. With all the excitement, my claws are a little out of control."
Marlena hums, letting her hand go before casually saying, "Well it's only going to get more exciting from here on out, so I suggest you cut them before the wedding."
She laughs politely, forcing down the disgust that rises at the idea.
"...Yes, well, as Lord Greyskull said, I ought to go tell my future sister-in-law the news."
"Adora's going to be so excited."
"I hope so."
She absolutely doesn't, she couldn't stand this kind of behaviour from her too.

"I said yes."
She holds up the heirloom dripping with diamonds and sapphires now on her finger. It was made for human hands and she can feel that now as she wears it: she's not *meant* to be wearing it. She loves Adora's window seat but has never felt more uncomfortable sitting here than now. The words just spill out. She was waiting for Adora to return to her side, but now she spins around in the door frame with Mara not even three steps down the hall.
"Oh." Adora's face breaks immediately upon seeing it and it *hurts*.
"You're not happy?"
She thought she would be. She thought Adora was disappointed

with her for not giving Adam an answer when he asked. Clearly that's what Adam thought too.

Adora's sorrow when she next speaks makes her ears flatten to her head, "No, I'm not. I'm sorry Catra, I know that's selfish of me but I don't want you to - I want you to be happy. You deserve it more than anyone, and if this is how that happens then I'll say nothing else, but -"
Adora cuts off, and Catra freezes. Adora's crying. She can smell her salt in the air and she rushes forward to hold her, reaching behind to close the door. She hopes Mara will knock when she returns with their tea. Adora wraps around her like they do when they're lying down together. It's near overwhelming when she's shaking in her arms, and then it gets worse when Adora goes and winds a hand into her hair. She forces a purr in an attempt at comfort, and Adora nuzzles deeper into her chest for the sound.

Adora not wanting this for her unless it makes her happy gives false hope. There shouldn't *be* any hope at all.
"Explain it to me, Adora." Because she can't let her heart believe she is this upset for any reason close to hers.
"You said it yourself that you don't want to get married. You don't want this, but I'm going to lose you anyway. And to my own brother at that." Adora's words are muffled but not enough that she can't hear them.
It's not what she wants to hear, but she's simply *never* going to hear that. At least Adora's fears are wrong and she can reassure her of that.
"Adora, he'll be good for me. And - and I'm doing this because he wants it and this will *stop* me losing you." She can feel her own tears stinging, hear them making her voice weak. She brings Adora's head up, and Adora's hands around her clutch tighter when she wipes her tears away with her thumb. "Don't you see? We'll be family, I'll be your sister, I'll - I'll have your nieces and nephews and… I'll lose you if I say no."

Adora looks about as shattered as she did when Adam proposed, and her eyes burn into hers as she brings their foreheads together. Adora *begs*, "You won't. You won't, I promise."

That is where she is *wrong*. Her affection won't keep her close this time. "Your father won't welcome me here. It'll be too painful for Adam to deal with if I keep coming back to see you. And then there's the rules about you leaving the grounds - "
"- I'll talk with him, to both of them. I love my brother but I care for you more. I will do whatever it takes to keep you with me. And I won't let you be forced into anything you don't want."

Catra fell asleep on her chest for hours, it let her anger calm but as soon as Catra is riding away in her carriage, Adora starts making directly for her father's study. She'll be talking to Adam after. He knows maybe a fraction of how much she loves Catra, needs her. He shouldn't even *have* a say in whether or not she's able to see her. Blonde hair passes her sights before her father's door does however, and he's unprepared for her to shove him into the wall (so is she in a way.) She doesn't care. They've done far worse in their rough-housing. She's never meant it before though.

"How could you do that to her?"
"Excuse me?"
"Catra couldn't say no! Not really! Our father won't let her come here if she rejects you for your sake!" She's panting with her rage and Adam's clearly not expecting it. Neither is she, but she should never be surprised how intensely she gets involved with matters regarding Catra.
They just stare at each other until she can't anymore. Until something awful sinks in; she loses Catra either way. But at least with a no she can *try* to visit Catra every day, if her brother whisks her away - the thought hurts something deep. She doesn't want Catra to be a distant *sister* of all things, she wants...she doesn't even know. She wants things to be as they've always been, she wants Catra to herself. And she knows her brother wants a family, it's what happens to all married couples. She feels sick imagining Catra pregnant, at not being able to be there for her everyday, caring for her. At seeing only portraits of Catra and Adam holding blonde kittens with eyes she shares.

The tears are back but she won't let them fall in front of him, she picks at the hem of her sleeves instead.
"Adora, I didn't tell him that. He has just *assumed* that. I wouldn't ban her from here just for rejecting me, especially when we haven't courted at all. But she has said yes, I was willing to give her as much time as she wanted… Miss Catra is in love with me, Adora, she told our father and he told me. I'm doing this to try and make her happy."
There's a pit in her stomach. "She what?"
Adam softens at how obviously small her voice is, she hates it but she needs him to be delicate right now. "It's why she's here so much, to be with you of course, but also...me, apparently. It gave me the encouragement to even think about proposing. And…I like her. Of anyone I know, being married to her sounds nice. She's my friend just as she is yours."
No. No he is not. He doesn't care for her like she does, he couldn't. No one ever could. He's never had Catra in his bed - but he will. Because Catra has said yes. The sickness gains nausea. *Nice*; that's the word he used. He should be ecstatic.

It takes her a few moments to recognise that Adam's still talking, "…You ought to understand why I might want her to be my wife. She's fun, witty -"
"- Never knows when to hold her tongue."
Even through her pounding head, she says it with the utmost affection. It's not true outside of their time together, and maybe it's petty to say knowing that Adam doesn't get to see that side of her. Or maybe he does, maybe she's been in the dark about how close they are this whole time.
He's undeterred, "I think marriage might calm her a little."
And then she's angry, suddenly and swiftly, "I should hope not. Don't you dare change her."
Of all things this marriage might do, that is the worst possible thing.

She doesn't talk to Randor. All her energy leaves as she walks back to her own room. She doesn't trust Adam to talk to their

father but...she can handle it some other time. Catra is in love with her brother, and admitted it to her father before her. She just wanted a choice in her answer, not to actually call it off. She curls up in the blankets that smell like Catra and doesn't understand exactly why she's crying.

Not all that much changes with the confirmed engagement. Marlena's behaviour doesn't exactly get worse. No, it's Mara who poses the most problems to her, she assumes that she's at the manor to see Adam now. Mara will tell her she'll let Lord Greyskull know that she's here and runs away before Catra can say otherwise. She stands in the receiving room hoping Adora somehow catches wind and finds her first, she never does. But sometimes she feels like she aches in those few minutes, waiting for Adora to come wrap her arms around her and steal her away.

The disappointment is still shockingly strong when Adam enters. He smiles when he sees her, full of open affection. "Miss Catra, walk with me?"
Adam holds out an arm for her to take, and she does, she's used to it now. She can do this part, where they walk in the sprawling gardens, it's innocent enough. And having someone she likes warm beside her in the autumn air is nice. She can do silence, can watch the fluttering of browning leaves. She feels a little bad for the gardener whom the Countess will make clear them up.

"What do you think our children will be like?"
She jolts to a standstill, any calm gone. Stars, she almost forgot her own harrowing situation. He doesn't make her walk again, just waiting until she manages to mumble, "…Small."
He laughs, it's not horrible. She likes making Adam laugh actually, something about a Lord, set to become an Earl, finding her funny. "Sorry, that came out of nowhere, I know. I've just been thinking about it a lot."
"As have I." It's not a lie. But he's speaking with fondness and

anticipation, she's been dreading it with every fibre of her being. There isn't a way out of it. People get married, they have children.

"Are you worried about having children?"
She whispers, "Yes."
His other hand comes up to cover hers. It's not awful. "That's alright. We can talk about something else. We have all the time in the world."
They don't. She doesn't at least, her whole life now feels like a clock about to strike. But she leaps at the change in subject gladly, still unable to look at him. "Tell me about your favourite books in that huge library of yours."

The wedding preparations, thankfully, haven't started since Randor is away by invitation of a friend of his, too important to turn down, and he needs to be here to oversee Marlena's financial decisions. Adora knows she'll be miserable when he returns - a new emotion regarding her father's homecoming. She spends far more time at Catra's home in the meantime, in the quiet alone with her and *far* from her brother. Though he did have the gall to show up at the door with flowers while she was here once. Catra left them out of water too long and they wilted. She didn't even bother to chide her for it, too happy about how little Catra cared. It's not fair to Adam. But none of this is fair to *her* either.

It's another such afternoon of her staring out onto the street with Catra beside her. They were talking but she can feel Catra's eyes just watching her now. It ought to be unsettling but it's not, not until Catra declares, "You're unhappy again."
Again. She's not used to sadness really, even when Catra was across seas she wasn't sad like this. "No, no I'm fine."
Catra's tail waves into her lap and she strokes gently along it. "You're not, I know you better than that."
Catra's lounged back on the sofa arm, in her more hybrid-friendly clothes that she likes seeing her wear, one arm over the back cushions with Adam's ring horribly glinting and distracting all her

focus.
"Do you want to go riding up on the hills?"
Catra does not share her love of horses in any way, the fact she is offering unprompted speaks to how low she must seem. But as much as she likes riding, all she wants to do is curl up with Catra here and be with her warmth.

"No, I want to stay here with you."
"Alright, my Lady. Mind if I read?"
She nods, aware of how her cheeks always heat whenever Catra calls her that. "Can I read to you?"
It'll give her something to think about other than...well, everything.
"If you want, go pick us something."
She chooses something she knows Catra's read many times, it means she's not too worried about misreading something. Catra rests her head in her lap and balls on the cushions immediately, purring happily. Breathing is hard because of it, focusing on the words in front of her is harder.

Every time she pauses too long, Catra chirps to remind her to continue, saying, "The next part is really good."
She's enjoying the story despite knowing it practically inside out just because Catra does, but her attention far prefers her best friend purring more.
She reads for nearly an hour before she says, "I think my voice is going to suffer for this."
Catra laughs a little, rubbing and marking her dress with her cheek as she mutters, "And it's such a pretty voice."

Her flush returns very suddenly and she is glad for Catra still having her eyes closed. She itches to touch her just as she has since sitting down with her. And she gives in, because Catra saying things like *that* makes her feel strange, and say strange things in return.
"Can I pet your ears?"
Catra blinks her eyes open, smiling, "Please."
She bookmarks the page and uses both of her hands to trace the velvety surface, grinning as the purr in the room rises to

something more resembling thunder.

Adora didn't think she was going to do this. But when she returns to the manor after having a whole day of Catra all to herself and uninhibited in her behaviour, and with Randor soon returning, something that's been bubbling up inside her has finally chosen today to be when she lets her thoughts lose. She finds Adam in the library, reading a book that she's seen on Catra's shelves, and she can't help wondering if he's reading it for her.

"Adam, we need to talk about Catra."
He puts the book down and shrinks a little at her harsh tone. "Alright."
Maybe the library isn't the place to have this conversation but there's no one to stop her. "You need to know how to take care of her and not offend her."
He blinks, clearly not expecting that. "I offend her?"
Not that she knows of but with marriage comes intimacy. He needs to know the things that she does to be able to keep Catra happy, even if it feels like she'd rather break a bone - or several - than let anyone else have her knowledge.
"You can easily, she's sensitive about her species even if she pretends she isn't."

"Go on then, tell me how to care for my future wife."
She grits her teeth, as she has been doing since he's taken to calling Catra that. It never sounds natural but she's about to tell her twin brother how to care for her best friend when he takes her away, she can't rule out that her own emotions aren't affecting her perceptions.
"She needs to have a low grain, low dairy, high protein diet. I told the cooks here years ago but if - you just need to know."
"Should I be making notes?"
She gives him a look (even though she secretly thinks *maybe*.)

“She loves being outdoors, needs to have spaces to climb and run. There will be claw marks in wooden floors from it and you cannot say a word.”
“Well, our mother has already asked her to cut -“
“- She has?”
He looks nervous, “Yes?”
“Stars above, Adam, what did you - you didn’t do anything at all, did you?”
“…No.”
She’s disappointed but obviously he has no idea - it’s why she’s giving him this lecture in the first place. “If I ever find out that you have asked Catra to cut her claws I will personally haunt you for the rest of your days.”
The threat doesn’t land, he tries for teasing, “As if you don’t do that already.”

She has a mind to shatter his ink pot just to make a point. “I’m not joking, Adam! If you can’t love her with her claws, you don’t deserve to love her at all.”
She’s never been *venomous* with Adam before, but this engagement has her being a lot of new things around Adam. And she’s not going to question it when she is right in what she’s saying.
He looks cowed, and there’s at least some satisfaction in that. “Just say what you came to say.”
“Her tail and her ears are delicate and you *cannot* be harsh with them in any way, and certainly do not touch them without permission. You need to be accepting of all her vocalisations, and her scenting, and her purrs -”
“- She purrs?” At least he has the appropriate response, face showing how adorable he finds the idea.
She hadn’t realised she was waving her hands until they fall to her sides again, “Yes, of - you *know* this.”

“I didn’t.” She doesn’t know *how*. But…she’s not unhappy that Catra’s never purred for him. “What’s scenting?”
She’s getting angry now, and she pinches the bridge of her nose. “Stars, Adam, really? You’ve known her for how long? It - she makes things smell like her by rubbing against them, it tells other

hybrids what's hers."
Adam smiles, she remembers when that used to make her smile too. "Will she do it to me?"
It douses the bubbling feeling, leaves her cold and upset. It keeps getting worse - she keeps *feeling* worse.

"Do you know why you do that?" She'd asked Catra that late at night during one of their first sleepovers after her return.
Catra was adorably close to sleep, purr fading with lulls in consciousness, and dragging her jaw across her collarbones. She thinks Catra would have done it to her face too - she has since - but she didn't want to move any more.
"Scenting. Makes you mine."
She remembers her chest erupting in a dizzying beat. *"I'm yours?"*
And Catra's purr abruptly halted as she snapped back to alertness.
"I can stop -"
"- No. I want to smell like you. I want everyone to know we're friends."
The relief at Catra going limp on top of her again was strong enough to leave her breathless. Almost as much as Catra happily telling her, *"You're sleeping in my bed, you're going to smell like me no matter what."*

One day she won't have Catra's claim on her anymore…and Adam will. She's tired of crying over this. She's tired of her chest hurting and not sleeping. She says defeated, "Yes. I imagine she will."
And she winces with the squeak of Adam's chair on the ground, flinching when he puts his hands on her arms. She keeps her head tucked into her chest as he asks, "Adora, what's wrong?"
Why can't she talk about this without crying? This shouldn't hurt this much, she's sure of it. She's more than ashamed of her broken whisper, "You never even thought to ask me."
"Ask you what?"
And then she's shouting with her eyes screwed shut, "If you could marry my best friend!"
She doesn't shout at him. But she has. And the guilt grows just as the tears start running down her face. So much for keeping this inside.

"…It's not your choice."
She knows that. It's the only reason she hasn't begged Catra to say no. "You could have told me you were thinking of doing it at all. It came out of nowhere for her and me. And - and suddenly you're just going to take her away, buy her a house and leave me behind."
His hands move to her back, he hasn't hugged her properly in a long time. She's just glad she can still feel comfort from it.
"That's what happens when people grow up. They get married, have families in their own houses if they want to. I...I don't know if we'll stay here forever, but I don't have any plans on leaving."

She doesn't care what other people do. It wasn't meant to happen to Catra. And Catra *doesn't want it*, but apparently she *does* and -
"So I'll just be waiting for the day when you decide you're bored here and take her away? Then I'll be waiting for the day our father dies and you come back here, you'll take control of the land and the house and the title. Adam, I can't live like that. I can't - you can't do this to us -"
"- Us?" He pushes her back slightly and she desperately hopes her face doesn't give too much away.
When did she get so selfish as to not include him in this? She is the third in this now, it's not her and Catra, it's Catra and Adam. It sounds *wrong*. It's not how it's meant to be. She just wants to be with Catra, that's all she's ever wanted. Catra is everything to her, she cares about her more than he does and she doubts she'll ever believe otherwise.

"…All three of us. You have to stay, or if you don't…promise to take me with you?"
"Yes, I can do that. You can stay with me - and Miss Catra - until you find a husband. You won't want to live with us after that."
She will want to be where Catra is, no matter the circumstances. She's sure of that.

Chapter End Notes

There is a 'The Great' reference in here actually
Exams mean finding brain power for writing is just non-

existent but this was already written and I can edit, hence I'll finish posting this before going back to the Killing Eve AU :)

III

Chapter Summary

:)

Chapter Notes

Warning for period-typical homophobic language but I promise this is a soft chapter by the end.

Adora is sick of hearing Marlena talk about the wedding and the planning hasn't even truly started yet. It's not enough that she's going to have to watch Catra and her brother promise themselves to each other, or watch them be happy without her, or even deal with every horrible worry-drenched thought about how Catra could be gone the next day if Adam wants it. No, she has to prepare herself for the supposed suitors Marlena wants to invite to the event for *her* as well.
"Weddings breed more weddings, Adora."
Apparently Marlena has been lenient with her dismissing suitors up till now. It might be something she regrets later, but after that revelation, Adora takes to looking out the window instead of listening to her mother whenever possible. Marlena's words just make her angry or sad or something equally bad. Worse is when Catra is subject to this as well, nodding mutely along to Marlena's ideas. They both know that she is not listening to anyone but herself when it comes to the wedding.

Today when it happens, Catra is standing next to Marlena in front of the window, arms crossed and her tail twitching. Adora knows her mother won't ever spend the time learning Catra to know how frustrated she is just by that movement. A few months ago she would have loved for her family to just *try* and understand her best friend. Adam has changed that, made her insecure and jealous about anyone else knowing Catra as well as she does. Marlena is talking about banners or flowers or something. It doesn't matter to her. It doesn't matter to Catra either apparently,

considering how she rolls her eyes with a smile when she looks over at her. It throws Adora back into a memory unexpectedly. But it's not as if she's never revisited the day Catra returned.

"Catra?" she had called from the entrance way.
And Catra had come slinking out from her sitting room, still in her travelling clothes with her hair unkempt. She'd rolled her eyes, smiled, and teased like no time had passed at all, *"Who else?"*
And Adora had been helpless but to do anything other than crush her into an embrace. She nearly cried from happiness when Catra's purr had started up in her arms. *"Oh, I've missed you. So much. Don't ever leave for that long again."*
"No promises, but I've missed you too, Adora."
Adora hadn't wanted to let her go but in the shock of getting to see Catra's face, now sharpened with age, she had let her slip out of her arms. There was enough the same; Catra's eyes were as striking as they'd always been even with the shadows of tiredness, her freckles bold against her cheeks and her mane wild and stiff with sea salt. But the childish softness in her features had left in its place a truly beautiful woman, she felt strange for being so captivated by her when her return was brought about by such miserable circumstances.

"How are you?"
"I don't know yet. He was the only one left and now… He took me in when I didn't - I'll figure it out later."
Adora hadn't been privy to Catra's complicated feelings about her uncle at that point, she's learnt now.
"I'll be here, whatever you need."
"I'm sorry I didn't come back sooner. I'm sorry we had to reunite because of this." Catra wasn't close to crying, but Adora remembers her ears drooping and her tail swaying slowly, and she has always been sensitive to Catra's upset.
"I am too. But you're here and you - you look wonderful. That might not be what you want to hear right now -"
"- No. No, it's alright, my Lady. You can tell me." She thought to herself that she must have missed Catra calling her that more than she had realised, because she couldn't stop her sudden and obvious fluster. She didn't care all that much when it gifted her

Catra's small genuine smile. *"You do too. Suppose the years have been kind to both of us."*
"Come," she had started dragging Catra back to her sitting room by her hand, something soothed by the feel of it after so long. Catra had gone with her easily, curled up with her on the sofa and pretending she didn't have a funeral to plan. *"Tell me everything, spare no detail."*

They are waiting for Randor's return before the engagement is made public. Catra didn't realise how much of her apathy with the situation is because so few people know; because she can still pretend for however long she has left. She's been wearing Adam's ring but the only people Catra knows who would think to ask about it, she hasn't visited since this began. If she were actually happy about the engagement she would've sent Scorpia and Entrapta a letter each immediately. Catra has just been distracted. And she doesn't want to have to handle their reactions. Entrapta won't care that much but she might interrogate, Scorpia will be sickeningly ecstatic. Still, they deserve to hear it from her and not a wedding invitation. She promises herself she'll at least draft something after Randor returns.

It could be in a few hours, tomorrow, or the day after. It's been fraying her nerves waiting, like watching something about to fall off a cliff. It makes it real once people know - stars, when people starting calling her his *fiancée*. She has had to grin and bear so many things during her life, but she doesn't know how *good* she is at it. She needs to look like she's happy but she *can't be* and what if people question her? What if *Adam* does, or Randor or Marlena or Adora or -
Catra finds herself packing an overnight bag before her spiral incapacitates her. When she arrives at the manor, horribly unannounced, she just demands, "*Adora*," before Mara can assume otherwise.

Maybe she’s just been acting too long, but when Adora comes into the receiving room, Catra wraps her up in a crushing embrace instantly. Adora’s scent and arms around her still brings the safety she’s always known, thankfully. She purrs weakly when Adora starts stroking her hair and she wants it so much, but not here. *Here* makes it feel like they can be stared at, *questioned* -
“What’s wrong?”
Of course Adora wants to know. Of course she can't hide this from her because is she even trying to? Catra buries deeper into Adora's shoulder, just breathing until there is at least a chance of her next words not sounding like a lie. “Nothing. Everything is perfect. Just…had a bad dream last night. Can we go to your room?”
“Of course.”

Adora walks with a hand on her back and it’s so hard to think. It’s nice to have her head be quiet for a moment, actually. Catra feels nearly all the tension leave when Adora’s bedroom door closes behind them. Nearly.
Adora climbs onto the window seat before she does and reaches her hands out for her. The adorable sight makes Catra’s stupid heart flutter. She crawls on beside her before pinning Adora to the plush bench. It is maybe too much for the radiant daylight pouring through the glass but she needs the comforting touch and she can’t wait for tonight when it’s so many hours away. Neither the position nor her coming here in the first place is a demand to be petted exactly, but Adora takes it as that and she doesn’t want her to stop. Her purr starts up again and she sets to marking every inch of Adora’s collar. Catra knows she’s overcompensating these days but she doesn’t care. The confusing storm in her chest is quieter so long as Adora is hers in this way.

“Are you sure you’re alright?”
Adora’s question startles her a little, but she responds quick enough, “I told you I was.”
Adora’s hands stop moving through her hair, laying gently on her shoulders instead. She raises her head, Adora looks sheepish, it’s sweet. “You’re not purring as loud as you usually do…”
Catra can’t help laughing a little, both to try and hide her fluster

since Adora knows her well enough to *tell*, and because of how embarrassed she seems to be saying it.
"Just a lot on my mind."
"Like what?"
She scoffs lightly, tapping her tail against Adora's leg through her dress. "Take a guess."

Adora wilts and she hates it. Catra…well she doesn't really know how Adora feels about all this. She doesn't *want* to talk about it, Adora clearly doesn't either given how she never brings it up. Maybe Adora's as upset by it as she was in the beginning - Catra's selfish enough that part of her wants them to be miserable together - but she doesn't want Adora *suffering* for this. Even if Adora being happy about it would be far worse.

Adora's hand twitches where it lies on her back, and she can feel her hold her breath under her before hesitantly saying, "Catra, there's something I don't understand."
She doesn't like what those words are following, and her tail hits the cushions in the silence. "And what is that?"
"I know that you're in love with Adam." Catra stops breathing, and she fights the way her body wants to flee from the words that are so *wrong*. "But the way you acted when he proposed - the way… You don't talk about it? I thought you would…"
No one has *questioned* it. Thought it was strange, maybe, but of course Adora would be the only one to say that to her face. She sits up, ignoring how panic flits across Adora's face as she does. She despises how Adora's hands hover and then fall as she follows, thinking better of touching her and carefully swinging her legs back to the floor.

"What are you asking, Adora?"
Her claws flex into her own thighs a little too deeply, something must give it away because Adora's hands are smoothing her fingers out. And then she's holding them like she hasn't just walked them to a threshold Catra's been terrified of since the moment she talked to Randor all those weeks ago.
"Catra, why didn't you tell me how you felt?"
She freezes, but Adora doesn't mean what her head is screaming

that she does. Catra's been so scared of her figuring it out for so long, but having her be upset for not *telling* her has never really crossed her mind. Maybe it should have. It is a lie by omission at this point. Every time she has Adora in her bed she is wanting more, thinking about more.
She snatches her hands back, "I can't tell you that."
"Catra, that's not fair. Not when I'm -" Adora cuts herself off, voice betraying her hurt as she looks at the opposite wall.
Catra knows she's not being fair but she's already close to tears with how scared she is. She stares at the light pink of Adora's cheek until she figures out that there's *guilt* there. "When you're what, Adora?"

Adora all but forces out, "Are you happy with this?" No. No, she's not happy with any of it. And everything is telling her to just admit that, but she doesn't answer quickly enough. "Catra, do you want to marry my brother?"
Stars, she's lied to her face so much - for *Adora's* sake - and it hasn't fixed anything. Catra's hurt her by doing this, it's obvious and she wonders how she missed it. She'd hold Adora's face in her hands if her thoughts meant she could do it without thinking about kissing her.
Instead she can't even look at her as she takes off the ring - his ring - and quietly admits, "No. I don't want to marry him. Or...any man."
The air moves beside her and Adora's hand lands gently on her thigh. She can't help the hitch of her breath. And then she's fighting to breathe at all as Adora does what she was thinking and cups the side of her face with her free hand to make their eyes meet. Adora's been doing this a lot more recently, and Catra's always so painfully aware of it. She wants to tell Adora that this is dangerous - and that's not *just* because of her feelings - but she also never wants to be anywhere else but held in Adora's gentle hands.

"Then why did you - I know what my father said but Adam doesn't care if you call this off, you can still come here. He can talk to Randor better than I can. You don't have to do this, Catra."
The pleading paired with Adora's thumb stuttering across her skin

constricts her chest and she fights holding onto Adora in turn.
"But I do. He might just be saying that to placate you and I can't risk that. I can't lose you. That's all I care about." Adora melts a little in front of her and her heart beats *so* loudly in her ears.
"Adora, I don't love Adam the way one should love their husband -"
"- So you lied to him, to my father?"
The safety of the moment breaks. Adora's hand drops from her face and she's confused by how Adora sounds; upset or hopeful or something else entirely. But she's not angry like she feared she'd be. Hope is always going to be what undoes her, it always loosens her tongue.
"…No. I said I thought I was in love, he made his own assumptions."

Catra puts the ring down on the window ledge to try and distract Adora from what she's just said. She doesn't want to *elaborate*. Whether it's the action or the words that cause it, Adora brightens properly for the first time in…a long time. There's relief, and she looks so pretty. It makes her heart ache, and she's smiling even with the fear hammering in her chest.
And a question appears, "Adora, why don't you want me marrying Adam?"
Adora blinks, clearly unprepared for it. The hand on her thigh twists some of the dark red fabric in it's fingers. "He'll take you away from me. Might take you away to some other house, you'll have…children. I couldn't bear to be worrying about you the whole time, nor can I stand the thought of not being with you through it. I'll just…*be here*. Alone and missing you, not being able to be in your life… I made Adam promise to take me with you but I don't know if I trust him to do that. Does that make me a terrible sister?"

Catra snorts quietly, then laughs properly at Adora's offended face. Adora may be smart but that doesn't mean she doesn't have her less fine moments. This is one of them.
"Oh Adora, you're not terrible. You never could be. If Adam thought for one second that we would live anywhere where I couldn't see you everyday, that was unbelievably foolish of him.

And if *you* thought I would then…" She finally finds the courage to hold onto the distracting hand, the both of them looking at the touch as she drags a claw carefully over the back of Adora's hand. "I guess we were worried about the same things."
"Catra…" She looks back up when Adora only says her name, just in time to watch her smile dim to something she's seen far too much of recently. "If you're not in love with Adam then who…?"

Her panic must show because Adora flips her hand over to be able to grip onto hers. Adora's eyes flick up by her head but she already knows her ears are pinned back. Adora wasn't meant to *ask that*. Because she *cannot* give her an answer. Her vision blurs as she just stares, paralysed.
"Catra? Catra shh, it's alright. Whoever it is, just tell me, please?" Catra *can't* be hearing the hurt there. But if she is then it's not - it's because Adora's upset that her best friend didn't tell her something so important. Not because she's hoping for a confession.
"Adora, there are some things that - I will lose you. I know you're scared of it happening, but you'll *want* to never see me again." Even saying that much has her chest twisting. Adora's brows draw together, it is concern but it's also Adora telling her that she's wrong. "That isn't possible, Catra. You know I adore you. I am begging you, tell me, I don't want you hurting over this anymore."

It's so close to what she wants to hear. It makes the first tear fall and Adora just brushes it away quietly before it can even stain her fur darker. And she whispers at the tenderness, "It's always going to hurt."
"Then let me share it."
Anyone else - anyone at all - and she would've told her long ago.
"It changes everything -"
"- Catra. If - if you really don't want to tell me, I can't force you. I'm never going to force you to do anything. I just want - I want to know everything about you. I always have and I always will."
"I don't want to keep secrets from you. But this - Adora, you're my best friend and…do you love me?"
It doesn't have to be romantic. She doubts Adora will even think of that. But she needs to know if she's going to even consider

confessing. If this is the last time she ever sees her, then she needs to give her the opportunity to say it. A softness overtakes Adora's face before she's pulling them closer and resting their foreheads together. She can feel Adora's breath on her face and she is fighting to keep herself from clinging onto her or doing something worse as she waits.
"Of course I do."

It's *not* 'I love you' or anything holding the weight her admission would, but it - it *could be* if she just had the courage to ask. Or to say it first. "You've never said it."
"Neither have you."
"That's only because - do you - I want to spend the rest of my life with you, Adora."
Adora's hands leave her face but it's only because Adora's wrapping her arms around her. Catra can hear her smile as she says, "As do I, that's all I want. I don't care what happens so long as we're together."
Adora's saying all the right things and this is so, *so* dangerous and everything is shouting to either tell her or run. She hides her face in the shoulder of Adora's dress and hugs her back.
"I want that - I want - stars, Adora, it's you."

It feels like her heart falls through her chest. It's so silent for so long and she cries silently into the fabric. But the hold doesn't break, the only reason she hasn't fled.
Adora whispers, "What do you mean 'it's me'?"
Catra's already doomed herself this far. This drop inside her won't disappear by running, in fact it might make it worse. But it's what she should do. And she just doesn't.
"I'm in love with you. I always have been." Her fingers are shaking as she lets go, scared of tearing the back of Adora's dress with her claws that won't obey her commands to retract. "Do you see? I never lied. And - and I would've told you if it were anyone else." Her voice is so broken and she hates it. And she knows she's ruined everything as Adora leans back to look at her. She screws her eyes shut, knowing full well how she'll crack if she sees hatred there.
"You…"

"I'll - I'll go." She stands, considering tearing her dress just so she can run from here faster. "I'm sorry, Lady Greyskull."

The only thing Adora can hear in her mind is *stay*. She grabs hold of Catra's wrist before she can run. "*Stay*, please Catra, just… *How*?"
It's the best she can do.
Catra freezes, claws black and glinting and maybe too close to the pulse in her wrist where Adora holds onto her. She knows what Catra said, she knows she means it. But she just can't *understand*. That's not - she can feel something in her chest that ignited when Catra said it but she doesn't know what it is. She *needs* to know what it is because there is a hope she hasn't felt in months.

Catra sniffles, still facing away from her, and she wants to pull her back into her arms and never let her leave, but she has a feeling it wouldn't be welcome.
"You really never did hear what they said about me, did you? What they still say..."
"No… What did - do - they say?"
Catra snatches her hand away and Adora almost leaps up to keep her here, but Catra just wraps her arms around herself practically snarling, "That I'm unnatural. A mistake. *Queer*. Men's clothes, that's *all it was*. They don't even know the thoughts I had about men's women."
"What were your thoughts?" she asks without thinking.
"You don't want to hear that, Adora."
She could agree but...she needs to know. It's *Catra*, she can't hate her, and she can't imagine hating her for - for being *in love* with her or anything else.
"I do."

Catra looks over her shoulder, tear tracks clear on her face. And when she doesn't retract her statement, Catra sighs and sits back down next to her, leaning over her knees with her head in her hands. Adora knows Catra can control her claws but she's still

worried about them when she's this distressed.
"I thought about their hands for hours if they happened to touch mine. I'd feel disappointed every time their husbands walked in the room. I wanted to steal them away for days on end and just - just hold them, touch them, talk to them. There was a performer in a theatre that I would meet after her shows. Every day for a week she'd take my arm and I'd walk her home along the river, and the whole time all I could think about was kissing her. I almost did...I think I would have if she had brought me inside. Regardless of the consequences. Then her fiancé returned, she told me it was too dangerous for us to meet again. I think that was the closest I've ever gotten to feeling about someone else the way that I do you, and even then…it was nothing compared to it."

It feels the same hearing this as it does when Adam talks about the marriage, up until the end. It takes Catra finishing her speech for her to realise that, however. For her to realise a few things. Like that she doesn't like sharing her, she never has. That she's thought about Catra's hands in unexpected detail; how they're rougher than hers, how much she likes the prick of claws when their fingers are laced together, how it feels like they leave marks where Catra touches. But this means she's not alone in her thoughts, or her feelings. Adora's had fantasies about getting days alone with her, able to touch her whenever either of them desires it. Getting to hear Catra's purr like a constant and see her wearing what she wants to.
Adora's never thought about kissing her though… She's thinking about it now. It seemed like Catra went travelling as the kitten she grew up with, adorable and with too much hair for her small frame, and came back as a stunning young woman. There's sharp edges and there's softness - her teeth the former, her lips the latter.

"The rumours have calmed with the years but it never really stopped. And people always forget about my hearing. I've had to bribe the police to let some scratches go."
It effectively snaps her out of her thoughtful state. Her gaze finds where Catra's claws are picking at one another. She never knew the police got involved, she wonders if Randor does. (Marlena

certainly doesn't). Adora would be surprised if he did considering how precious he is with their name. But then again, he has always seemed at least a little sympathetic to Catra's case.
"You should have told me. I would've helped you."
She puts her hand on Catra's shoulder. It makes Catra finally come out from her hands, her tail snapping behind her as she whispers with a hiss, "And what would I have said? Adora, I thought you were going to hate me! If your parents knew the rumours were the truth..."
"They don't. They would've told me in an attempt to steer me away from you. But Catra it *wouldn't have worked*, do you believe me now? I *can't* hate you." There's no purr, just a broken smile overlaid on top of tears. "I know I don't stand up to my parents all that often but when I do it's in defence of you. They know they lose me if they were to cast you out. Or if they don't know then I will make it clear. I can do a lot to our name."

Catra's tail curls up and around her arm but she can't look away from the teasing look on her face, too delicate to be believable.
"Are you - Adora, are you threatening the Grayskull lineage just to be with me?"
"Yes. I suppose I am."
There's conflict paired with a genuine smile. And Catra's gorgeous, she's always thought so. Maybe that has some deeper meaning. Adora moves her hand to cup Catra's face again, unable and not wanting to stop herself. She hopes Catra is not still scared of her reaction, she doesn't seem to be as she relaxes into her hand. Adora realises that she's breathless, it's not even uncommon for her to feel like this…stars, there's things she's just never thought might mean anything. But *maybe they do*.

She's already said it, but saying again and with her following question has her heart racing, "Catra, I - I love you. I don't know if I'm - can you just…*explain* how you're *in* love with me?"
Catra opens her eyes and looks at her like she's said something unbelievable. "*How*? I - Adora, you are the most wonderful person I have ever met. You're kind and loving and funny and caring. And you'll do silly, childish things with me and you don't care about proper unless it'll get us both in trouble if we're not. Every

moment away from you - I want to be with you all the time. I'll never be able to be sick of you. How could I not be in love with you? You make me feel so much and so *good* that I've denied so much of myself just to keep you, I've risked people knowing my… secret just to... You're my best friend, and the love of my life, no matter what happens."
"Catra…" Adora knows she breathes her name. She doesn't care. She feels like she's melting, like her heart has never beaten faster. And she just wants to be close to her and she doesn't know for sure but she knows she won't regret asking, "Kiss me?"
"What?"
"I want you to kiss me."

For several long moments Catra just flicks between her eyes like she's trying to find the deception. She must not find any because she cautiously reaches up with both her hands to hold her face. Adora loves this feeling, she always has. Catra looks like she's about to ask something more, she looks as nervous as Adora feels, and then there's a flicker of something like determination that she suddenly can't see because Catra's lips are on hers. They're as soft as she was musing. It is a connection she's never had with someone before, and stars is she happy it's Catra.
'There's never going to be anyone else.'
The thought is sudden and swift and she knows it's the truth, even if she doesn't know anything else. Every thought is just this wonderful woman in her arms, it feels simultaneously dangerous and the safest she's ever been outside of Catra's bed. She feels Catra's purr through her lips, through the hand she has on her face. And Catra doesn't protest in any way when she lays a soft hand on her chest to feel it there too. The kiss breaks and she chases it, Catra lets her. It's just a precious connection for another second or two, but stars does it mean everything to her.

She whispers, so aware of Catra's breath against her lips, "I've never done that before."
"Me neither."
"Really?" She sounds pathetically hopeful.
"No." Adora knows she is smiling so widely that she'd be self conscious of it if Catra could actually see. And then it shatters

because Catra asks, completely fragile, “You’re not disgusted by this?”
“No. No, I’m *happy*. You always make me happy. And *this* feels amazing.” Catra’s purr pours out between them and she really wants to kiss her again. “You’re my whole world, Catra.”
“You’re mine too.”
Adora loves it when Catra’s purr has to pause for her to talk and it makes her voice lower. Adora loves her, she’s sure of that.

But the kind of love Catra is declaring was always with a man, it always lead to marriage. Adora would always be wondering if *he* felt the same as she supposedly would, or if it was just for her title and money. There was always children looming over it like a dark cloud. She wanted it because she was told it would make her happy, that it was what she is supposed to want. But...she doesn't, she would have given into her mother by now if she did. Adora's always known that she'd be happy with Catra for as long as she lives, this hasn't changed that. If anything it's made that resolve stronger, it's all she can feel in her chest. If she loves Catra this way...
“Catra?”
“Yes?”
“How did you realise what you were feeling?”
Catra hums, fingers tracing along her cheek in a way that makes her feel light-headed. “I wasn’t sure for a long time. I thought to myself that oh, I’ve always felt this way about you, it hasn’t changed. I’ve always loved holding your hand, I love our sleepovers, waking up with you. But then I went away, and I just missed you so much. I left a part of me here with you. And I learnt things and…I don’t know. I thought about you the way lovers are meant to. As soon as that part clicked it was so *loud* all the time. And any break I get from it I’m thankful, those times when I can be with you and just be your best friend. Sometimes I think that I fell for the wrong twin but he’s not you. He’ll never mean to me what you do. I fantasise about being able to dance with you in the evenings, and getting to greet you with a kiss on your hand or - or your lips. I want you to live with me, I want you in my bed every night.”

Adora pulls Catra closer by her hips till she's practically in her lap, she’s never thought about doing it before, she just did it. And Catra's still purring so she doesn't feel any bad way about it.
“We can do all of that.”
“You want to?”
Adora could never say no to that blatant hope in her voice. “I think so. No - no, I know I do.” Catra pulls back and she worries she said something wrong but the utter softness in her eyes reassures. (It does more than that.) Catra takes a deep steadying breath in front of her and Adora reaches up to pet her ears with one hand. “You don’t believe me, do you?”
“I’m trying.”
“I could kiss you if that would help?”
It gets Catra to laugh prettily at least, and her eyes flick down. But Catra shakes her head, hands moving to her shoulders and her purr quieting. “The window, Adora. I wasn’t thinking.”
The fear in her voice is real, and it’s sobering to how Catra’s been living with this alone for *years* while she has no idea. “How dangerous is this?”
“It’s not *illegal*, but it is between men. People can’t know. Let them think what they want but we don’t act any differently around them.”

Catra keeps looking out the window, probably thinking about the things Adora doesn’t know yet.
“Catra, do you remember when Adam was away and you dressed up in one of his suits?”
Catra blinks, turning back to her and taking a moment. “That - that kind of started it all, Adora, so yes. I always worried how you truly felt about me doing it, about how much I liked it.”
Adora shakes her head at her, winding Catra’s tail around her wrist for grounding. She’s the only one Catra let's do this. “I told you I didn't care, and that wasn't a lie. I always want you to look at happy as you did that day. It looked *right* and you were - stars, I'm so stupid. I thought you were so beautiful and so handsome and that *meant something*. Catra, I don’t feel anything like what I feel for you about anyone else. I never thought there was a limit to how much one could love their best friend but...Glimmer

doesn't even come close to *this*. Is - is it love?"
She wants it to be, nevermind the danger, she just wants Catra to be happy. Adora wants to feel it with her, to be the cause of it.

"I can't tell you that…" Catra starts stroking her cheek again. "You really haven't thought about this before, have you?"
"No, this is terrifyingly new. And…you're still going to marry my brother."
Catra chews her lips for a second, then pulls her up to stand unexpectedly. "I won't. Not when it'll make both of us miserable. Not now you know. He may be the best option I'll ever have, but I'll be a ruin of a wife for him. I can't give him what he wants. I'll be a liar, and an adulterer, because if you are happy for me to, I will never stop doing this."
Catra pulls her down with a hand on the back of her neck, and she makes an embarrassing little sound when they kiss that Catra definitely hears. They're safely out of the way of the windows, she's sure that's why Catra's kissing her hard enough, and insistently enough, that she's dizzy when it ends.
"I don't want you to stop doing that."

Catra purrs louder and she feels it in her lips when she kisses her again. It's easier to put her hands on Catra's waist this time, it feels right to do it. Catra gasps quietly and she takes the opportunity to flutter kisses over Catra's jaw. It makes her laugh and Adora's heart feels like it's bursting. She only stops once she's breathless.
"Stars, Catra. What are we going to do?"
Catra winds her arms around her neck. "End my engagement. After that...I don't know. You could come live with me, or we could run away. Or just travel, I think you might like seeing the world with me. I really did not do the places I saw justice when I told you."
Adora's never thought of leaving. She's not sure why she hasn't, the only consequence would come from her family and they wouldn't be able to find her. It's not like she has duties like Adam does, she could write to her friends. She'd miss them but she'd have Catra. She could just…leave.

“Can I have some time for the last part?”
“Of course… And the rest?”
Adora doesn't think she *could* say no to her now. "I want that. I want you. End things with Adam and I'll be there, I don't know what I'll tell my parents yet but...I'll be all yours." Adora doubts she’s ever seen Catra happier, and everything feels *right*. Catra’s purr is just…enchanting really. She’s always thought so. "Stay tonight?"
"I'd love to, my Lady."
"Don't you even dare try to spend a second in any bed other than mine."
Catra laughs and wraps her arms around her neck, kissing her lightly. “I take it we are ending everything tomorrow then?”
“Yes.” Adora kisses her this time, long and lingering. “There’s so much for me to think about.” And she does it again, loosing her ability to speak coherently piece by piece. “But I just want to do this for a while.”
“Whatever you want, my love.”

IV

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I'm sorry Lord Adam, I am, but I can't marry you. I'm not worthy of your station."
Catra makes herself watch his face break. She's put Adora and herself through so much pain by denying her own feelings. And now she's got to hurt him too. Maybe she shouldn't feel like he's earned at least some strife for springing a life-changing question on her but she's never said she was a good person.
Adam's hand drops where he was about to reach out for her. "You've always been welcome in this house despite that. You *are* worthy of this, of being my wife and a Greyskull."
She doesn't really believe any of that. This house has only ever been welcoming when Adora is in the same room, and she will never be a Greyskull. She's not built for it. Catra's always been out of place whenever Adora invited her to the high society parties, but Adora allowed her to forget. A lifetime of them on his arm would've been wrong and painful.

She prepares herself for the lie she and Adora crafted, it is harsh but it needs to be. Marlena and Randor won't accept anything else and this needs to be a clean break. Catra plays with the ring on her finger, not exactly savouring the last time she'll ever wear it, but maybe lamenting the safety of the life she's giving up.
"My Lord, I know how important children are to you. My mother died giving birth to me, my whole family is dead and…and I guess it's for a reason. My health isn't as it should be. The doctors warned me years ago that I would be lucky to carry for anyone other than another of my species - there is a reason we are so rare - and that if I did survive it'd be a miracle. Our children shouldn't grow up without a mother like I did. And I don't want to die."

Adam looks betrayed with the words, it worsens as she hands the ring over. He looks like how she felt when he offered it to her in the first place. There's guilt, of course there is. But she knows it would be so much worse if they'd gone through with the wedding, if she'd lived the rest of her life lying to him, raising children she doesn't want *if* the pregnancy didn't kill her. Maybe she could've been happy so long as Adora was with her, being with her as she was last night and this morning. She's not willing to risk it.
Adam stares down at the sapphire for a long time. The wind in the gardens messes with Catra's skirts and she wants to leave, but she's not so selfish as to actually do that.
Eventually he looks up at her again, "You should have told me. I wouldn't have asked if I knew, I care for you Miss Catra, I don't want you to be in pain. And I wouldn't forgive myself if I - if you died for something I put you through… My sister wouldn't either."
She's not even going to try and think about that. "…Lord Greyskull, you are not in love with me."
It's meant to be reassuring to him, and give another reason to end this, but he wilts, seeming like he's long since accepted that. "You're the closest I think I've ever come."
"I'll take that as flattery."

"Does this hurt for you?"
Given how confused his voice is, how uncomprehending he is of how she *should* be feeling, for once Catra is glad she doesn't love him the way she's meant to. Or maybe she's just a worse actor than she thought and he can tell.
"Yes. But it's been hurting for a long time." And hopefully it won't after today.
"I am sorry, about your condition, and about giving you hope for us." There's at least empathy in that.
"I'm strong. I can take it."
"I know that. I admire you for it."
She puts her hand on his wrist where he's still turning the ring over. "Thank you. You'll always be my friend, Lord Greyskull. But I imagine we won't be seeing all that much of each other for a while."
He looks sad, and she is too. Catra's seen him most days since

she returned from abroad, losing him won't decimate her but it's still a loss.
"No, I suppose we won't."

"Tell your parents about everything, I don't think I can." And now for the part she's most worried about. "Adora's going to stay with me for a while, to…help."
Adam's shocked, clearly. But it doesn't last unsettlingly long, he accepts it easily. It does make sense - she hopes at least.
"Well, I hope she can console you. She's always been good at it."
"Isn't that what best friends are for?"

Adora only decides to tell her parents that she's going to be staying with Catra as her trunks are being loaded into the carriage. The Earl and Countess come out of the study, a sunken Adam following and swiftly leaving the room, and Adora knows exactly what has just happened. She doesn't care, she is happy, and if they try to stop her doing this, she's already practised the threats.

Catra came to her room immediately after talking to Adam, slinking into her arms and showing off the distinct lack of a ring. Adora can still feel the pressure on her lips from how many kisses they stole while she was packing. Catra stood behind her, holding her the way no one ever has. It was gentle and loving and it made Adora's heart beat out of her chest. And she flustered each time Catra whispered compliments about how pretty she looked in the dresses that went into the cases one by one.
If Adora's not careful, she's going to start blushing for seemingly no reason in front of her whole family just remembering that. Catra's only been gone an hour, she shouldn't be this desperate for her.

Randor seems solemn, maybe it's acceptance, maybe it's anger. Adora's never been able to read her father well. Marlena is more obvious, at least right now. Her anger is present and she's always disliked Catra the most, but she was also excited for the wedding.

“Miss Catra should have mentioned her condition earlier.”
“It's not something she thinks about often and she was scared, mother. Of what you might say about her if you knew, of what you might do if she rejected him.” She’s never been good at lying, but saying that is close enough to the truth as she knows it. And it lets her show some of the anger she’s been coveting against both of them for years.
Marlena looks a little shameful, it doesn’t stop her saying, “It is selfish though, is it not? To keep something like that hidden, to allow for the engagement to fail.”
Adora sighs, hoping Mara will just come now to tell her everything is ready. “It wasn’t public knowledge. Our name will be intact. I shall see you Sunday for lunch.”

For the first time Randor speaks, “And where exactly are you going?”
“I'm staying with Catra for as long as she needs, she’s distraught. Getting what she wanted only to lose it, especially when she’s lost so much already in her life.”
“You didn’t ask my permission.”
“I’m doing it either way.”
Randor is, unsurprisingly, shocked. Marlena is near gaping. Adora would love for Mara to just appear at the window so she could escape now. But leaving with them angry will just make them come after her.
Marlena, unfortunately, recovers the quickest. “Don’t speak like that to your father.”
“Apologies. This situation has been stressful for me as well. But I am leaving.”
Her mother starts again, “Adora -“
“Marlena, no. It’s alright. She can go.” Adora breathes a sigh of relief, and a ‘thank you’ is sitting on her tongue when he cuts her off. “We will see you Sunday. I do not think I need to tell you not to bring Miss D’riluth?”
“No. It would be too painful for them both, I understand.”

As soon as Catra gets to her townhouse, she goes to the kitchen to tell Rogelio that Lady Greyskull will be staying with them for the foreseeable future. She doesn't bother to hide her glee at all, if Rogelio notices the lack of a ring paired with her smile he doesn't say anything.

Waiting is awful. The part of her that doesn't believe this is real whispers that Adora won't be able to stand up to her parents, that they'll have to tiptoe around everyone and spend weeks apart. She could survive it. She feels like she can survive anything now that Adora *knows* and wants to be with her. But she would still *want*. She always does.
Not watching out the window is a feat she does not complete successfully. Sure, she sits down to read in the back of the sitting room, but the window is still *there*. It just means when the Earl's carriage rides up, she is at the door before the footman even rings. It feels like a mirror of her return from her travels; Adora bounding into her arms and crushing them together. She lets her purr loose freely. And this is too much for the open door onto the street. She turns her head out from Adora's neck to call for Rogelio to help the footman with *her Ladyship's* things.

"Come on, you can actually have your own room this time."
She pulls Adora up the stairs behind them, both of them grinning like it's the only chance they'll ever get to. Adora halts at the top, confusion setting in, "I get my own room?"
Catra can't stop herself laughing, she knows exactly what Adora was thinking. "You sound surprised?"
Adora blushes and she can't wait for a door to close behind them so she can kiss her. "We've - I've always - your room -"
"- Relax," she cuts off Adora's stutter, "It's just for appearances. You can be in my bed as much as you want."
Adora sighs, reaching out for her hands, "Good, because I really want to be in your bed."

Catra trills, it's not covered by the sound of the door closing as Rogelio finishes bringing all of Adora's things inside. They're not nearly as sheltered as she would like to be on the upper landing, but she doubts Rogelio would tell anyone even if he did see

something (she has suspicions about him and the grocery boy.) And Adora has just said *that*, so Catra figures she is at no fault by pushing Adora up against the wall and kissing her soundly. She smirks when Adora tries to follow her lips after.
"Even if you want a night alone, I'm only a wall away, my Lady."
Adora flushes worse at that, and Catra steps back from her when she hears Rogelio picking up a trunk downstairs. "Rogelio will bring your things up, then stay in your room. Knock on my wall when you're alone, I have a surprise for you."
"You do?"
Catra leaves her by the wall, telling her yes before slipping into her own room.

Adora's never been more ready for a surprise in her life. Trying not to let it leak through too much as Rogelio makes the few trips to her room is far more difficult than she was anticipating. As soon as the door closes for the final time she's knocking on Catra's wall. There are barely a few steps between their rooms but Catra takes her time, enough that she can sit back down on the bed, Catra even opens the door slowly because she is *cruel*.

Normally the smirk that Catra wears as she stands in the doorway would be enough to draw all of her attention. But she's in suit tails. Maroon with black detailing and a black shirt, with a matching hat like gentleman wear. It's clearly been made for her or taken in to fit or *something* because she looks completely stunning and it fits with her tail and ears.
"You like it, my Lady?"
By the way the tip of Catra's tail is flicking, Adora knows she really cares how she replies. It's foolish of her to be worried, as if she wouldn't like this. "Yes. Yes, very much. You're - you're the most handsome woman I've ever seen."
The thin bravado fails entirely, and Adora wonders if she's ever made Catra truly blush before - to this point where the red shows through the fine fur on her cheeks. She must have, but right now she doesn't have the capacity to remember.

Catra comes into the room proper and closes the door behind her. She doesn't come close enough to touch sadly, but Adora can hear how she's already purring. Catra's hair has been tucked under the top hat to make it seem short, oddly it's different considering she sees Catra with her hair up often.
"Adora?"
"Yes?"
"Come kiss me?"
She's on her feet immediately, feeling slightly out of control of her body and not caring as soon as she's kissing Catra. No matter how many times they did it yesterday, she's still desperate for it, tugging on Catra's lapels. She knows Catra can hear her pulse racing with her joy and excitement. Catra's gentle hands on her hips reads like she's telling her to slow down, and she listens, but barely. She's still pressing close enough that Catra's hat goes tumbling to the ground.

Catra giggles against her lips, completely unrestrained. They're free in this house, they have been since Catra came back. But it's almost overwhelming now. She doesn't want to stop kissing her - she keeps trying to pull Catra closer - but her breath is failing. There's a sting in her eyes but it's all happiness. Catra breaks it before she does, and Adora clings onto her tighter, sliding her hands around Catra's shoulders.
"I love you, Catra."
She said that a lot yesterday, not having realised the words were chained down waiting for Catra to say them first. It's what she *needs* to say in this moment.
Catra hums into her cheek. "I love you too."
Catra rubs a scent mark into her jaw, the hands on her hips sliding up her back makes Adora melt in her arms. Catra tilts her head in an invitation to kiss her again and it feels wrong to hold herself back but she needs to tell her, "Catra, I'm - I'm *in* love with you."
Catra pulls back, disbelieving again like she absolutely shouldn't be. "Are you sure of that now?"
"Yes." Adora presses quick kiss to Catra's lips before pulling her down to sit beside her on the bed.

"I've been thinking about my books, how you elicit the same reactions in me. How I can so easily imagine holding your hand in *our* house and curling up with you by the fire in the winter. I've realised how long my eyes would linger on you when we would dress down at night. How completely far from friendship every want I've ever had while I'm in bed with you has been."
Catra smiles, dark and sweet. And then she swings her leg over so she's sitting in Adora's lap. It is *new*. Far from bad. Catra, her *love*, is sitting in her lap in suit tails; she could not *be* upset.
Catra cups her jaw and she has to fight closing her eyes. "When did you have the time to think about all this?"
"You fell asleep before me last night. And the ride over."

Catra rolls her eyes, but her expression is completely besotted and there's a tear-shine, so it doesn't work at all. "It's - stars, you have no idea how long I've waited for this."
"I've been waiting too, I just didn't know it. Catra, I've been dedicated to you for so long that this feels natural, this feels like what was meant to happen."
"I -" Catra really seems to try to find the words, but it just ends with a long, slow kiss. "You know I don't believe in fate."
"But I do. And my fate lies with you, my love." The name just rolls off her tongue, like she's been calling Catra that their entire lives.
Catra trills, ducking her head into her shoulder and purring. "Just you."
Adora holds her tightly to her chest. It's barely even the afternoon, but just like yesterday, all she wants is to just hold Catra under covers - without Catra worrying about what's too much. They have tonight. They have tomorrow morning. They have days for that. She doesn't need to be patient and just *hope* for it anymore.

Catra keeps the suit on for the rest of the day, just to indulge in the way Adora looks at her. Even as they're eating, Adora keeps dragging her eyes over her, and she wonders if Adora's always wanted to look at her like this. She lets Adora finish her meal before actually addressing it, putting all the sly teasing that she

can into her words.
"I don't think you've stopped looking at me since I put this on, my Lady." She runs her tail up Adora's leg, laughing quietly when Adora jumps slightly.
"Catra, imagine if I -" Adora starts with a flustered snap then seems to remember herself and brings her voice down to a whisper, "Imagine me in a suit. Would you be able to keep your eyes off me?"
"No." Catra doesn't even need a second to think about. She believes she would fare better than Adora has - or at least be more subtle - but not by much. "I didn't truly appreciate you in Adam's clothes. I'm regretting that now. Do you want to try it again?"
"A suit? Yes. It was comfortable. And…and I like you looking at me."

Catra can't kiss her here with the window onto the street and Rogelio in the kitchen. So she stands, coming behind Adora and resisting dragging her hands along Adora's shoulders by gripping onto the back of the chair. Adora freezes when she feels her leaning over, her breath hitches when Catra's hair brushes the back of her neck.
Catra whispers into her ear, "My Lady, would you care to follow me to *our* room?"
She walks away before Adora can respond, slinking through the doors and back up the stairs. She laughs hearing Adora's small scramble up to standing.

Adora catches up to her in her bedroom doorway and Catra spins around to kiss her, reaching blindly for the door handle and locking it.
"Don't say things like that where I can't kiss you."
"No promises, my love."
Adora gets another kiss for that. It feels safer to do this in the twilight, but Catra still goes over to the window that overlooks her garden and shuts the curtains.

She turns back, taking off her jacket and laying it over the chair by the wardrobe. "Early night?"

Adora nods eagerly and then freezes when Catra starts undoing the buttons of her shirt. She knows Adora used to watch her undress but *Adora* obviously wasn't aware of that given her confession earlier, now she blushes the whole time. It's wonderful. By the time Catra slips a normal nightshirt on, Adora's got her arms around her and kissing her shoulder just like Catra did to her this morning. It's so nice. She doesn't want to move ever again.
"You're beautiful." She's not used to this. Stars, she doubts she ever will be. "I've thought about drawing you before but you know I'm awful at it."
Catra could draw herself if Adora wanted a picture, she does like drawing, and maybe she will. But she wants something immortalised. "We could get a portrait done. Just the two of us."
"I'd like that. You've never been painted before have you?"
"Once. I made a friend abroad and they wanted to see if they could paint fur."
"Could they?"
"Well enough."

She turns in Adora's arms, dragging a claw gently down her chest, "Your turn, Lady Greyskull. Off."
"Help me?"
Adora asked her the same thing last night, she undid the buttons on her back then too. The freedom in not having to crush down how fluttery the process makes her feel is still present today. Taking her time peeling the fabric away is new, however. She just soaks in the intimacy, Adora's quiet breathing and faster-than-usual heartbeat. Catra scent marks her shoulders and her arms and her neck and she can tell from Adora's hums and smile that she would be purring if she could. Undoing Adora's stays with her claws is never easy, but Adora's giggling, as always, succeeds in diffusing her frustration.
"Take your hair down…please?" She asks her when the panel is loose enough.
Adora complies and Catra's still as mesmerised watching her hair fall around her as she always has been.

Catra wastes no time after that, drawing the covers back and pulling Adora down on top of her. They don't often lie like this

since Adora likes having her weight and purr on top of her, but Catra likes being able to bury her face in Adora's hair. Especially when it's down at night. She cards her claws through it now and Adora softens, winding her arms under her back and nuzzling into her chest.
They can clean up for bed later. Now this is all she needs; her best friend, her *lover*, content in her arms.

Chapter End Notes

> The distinction between loving and being in love is very personal to me.
> Maybe I end too many fics with them falling asleep together but I don't care. Bed sharing is a catradora cornerstone.

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